

Erasmus and humanism



Towards the end of the 15th century, political power was shifting from the Roman Catholic Church to secular nation-states. Intellectuals had become less interested in theology and concerned themselves more with earthly matters. This new emphasis on 'humanism' had an effect even within the the Church. Medieval scholasticism had sought to reconcile rational philosophical thinking with Christian theology, but there was a growing feeling that the two should be kept separate – philosophy is based on reason, but religion on faith.

Dutch philosopher Desiderius Erasmus, however, took on board the humanist emphasis on the individual, arguing that an individual's relationship with God was more relevant than Catholic doctrine. He suggested that the values of simplicity, naivety and humility advocated by the Christian scriptures are fundamentally human traits. Knowledge, especially of the kind discussed by philosophy, is an obstacle to leading the 'good life' exemplified by Jesus, and a hindrance to faith.